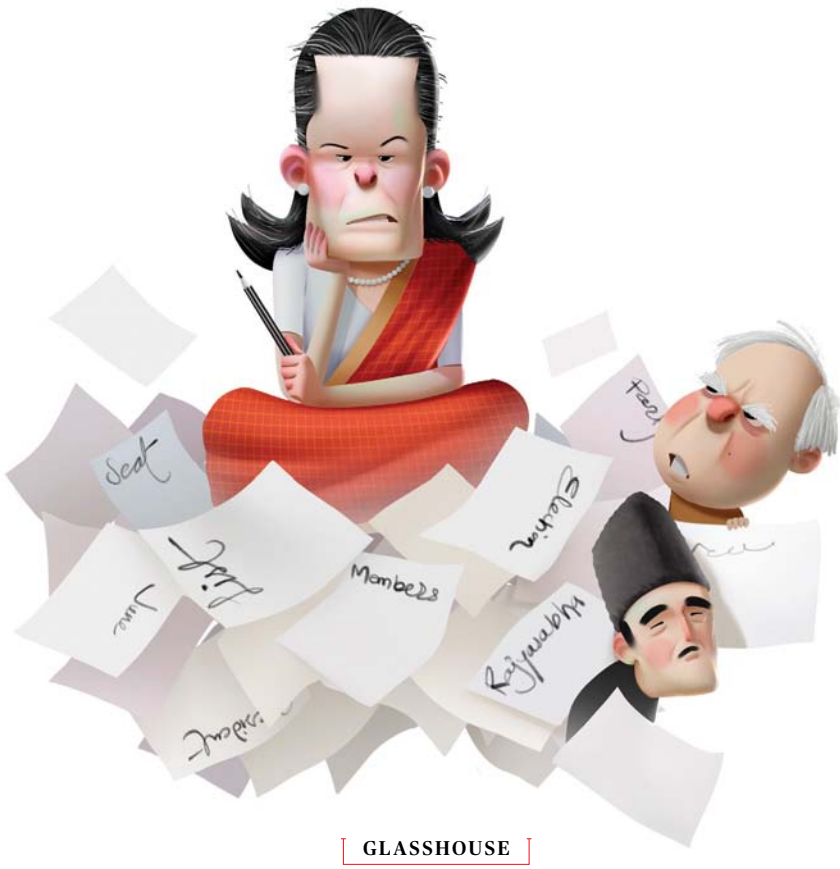


Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

RUSH FOR UPPER BERTH

Elections to the Rajya Sabha in June have added to the headache of Congress president **Sonia Gandhi**. In 14 states, 53 seats are up for grabs. Seven leaders, including Ambika Soni, P. Chidambaram and Jairam Ramesh, will retire. While Sonia is likely to renominate them, she has few options for other aspirants. The party has little chance to elect candidates in Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, UP, Punjab, Odisha, Bihar, and Uttarakhand, which account for 27 seats. In Chhattisgarh and Rajasthan, it can win most of the six seats, in Karnataka one seat—that of Ramesh—is almost certain. Allies may offer seats in Tamil Nadu, Maharashtra and Jharkhand. At best, Congress can add three more to its 29 members. While two G23 members, **Ghulam Nabi Azad** and Anand Sharma, hope for good news, another one, **Kapil Sibal**, got Samajwadi Party's backing for a seat.



For Yogic Calm

As India celebrates 'Azadi ka Amrit Mahotsav', International Yoga Day on June 21 will be celebrated at 75 iconic locations across the country. PM Narendra Modi will lead the mass yoga demonstration event in Mysuru. West Bengal Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee has remained indifferent to all this. When a reporter recently asked Ayush Minister **Sarbananda Sonowal** if he was expecting her cooperation this year, he replied: "She should practise yoga herself. It will calm her down."

COLOUR CHALLENGED

Already at loggerheads with the BJP-led Centre on multiple issues, Jharkhand Chief Minister **Hemant Soren** has found one more battle ground. His government's decision to paint over 35,000 government schools with a fresh coat of green and white, colours otherwise associated with the flag of Soren's party Jharkhand Mukti Morcha, has made the BJP see red. Jharkhand school buildings were earlier painted pink and blue. BJP spokesman Pratul Shahdeo said the decision was politically motivated. Are saffron leaders turning green with envy?



–Kaushik Deka with Amitabh Srivastava, Anilesh S. Mahajan and Prashant Srivastava



PRISON DIARY

Convicted in a road rage case, Congress leader **Navjot Singh Sidhu** has been meditating a lot. He has been kept in the barrack in Patiala Central Jail where drug and arms smuggler Inderjit Singh is lodged. Sidhu was vocal against drugs. In a nearby barrack is his bitter rival Bikramjit Majithia, an undertrial in a drug related case. Sidhu has been demanding low carb food and did not touch the jail fare for 24 hours. A medical board will examine his health and assess his requirements. Till then, he can meditate more.



Leader Hunt

In Uttar Pradesh, the BJP, SP and Congress are all looking for a new president. BJP state unit chief Swatantra Dev Singh is now a minister in the state cabinet. UP Congress president **Ajay Kumar Lallu** resigned following a disastrous outing in the assembly polls. The Samajwadi Party is also likely to replace its state chief Naresh Uttam. While the BJP and SP are yet to show their cards, former Union minister P.L. Punia and former MP Nirmal Khatri have emerged as frontrunners in the Congress.